

MOTION SICKNESS

— VOL 1 —



Motion Sickness
Volume 1

Warrior Bookworms
&
Wordsmiths

White Crow Press

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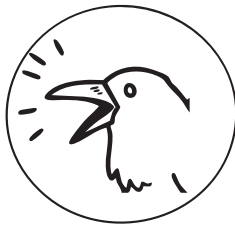
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The Bloom of Scholarship: Conference Proceedings as Living Media

Tony Perrello

Maybe you heard it from Robin Williams as John Keating in the 1989 film *Dead Poets Society*, or maybe in Apple's iPad commercial several years ago—the pop-culture echoes of Walt Whitman's inspiring exhortation that life's "powerful play goes on, and you may contribute a verse." While Whitman's words speak broadly concerning the potential of each individual in the evolving human story, there is special meaning in his lines for the community of the university. Here, we take Whitman's challenge seriously and literally. Here, to "contribute a verse" means to share in the lifeblood of academia: to question, to research, to analyze, to create, to push the boundaries of knowledge, to write, to publish. This is the long conversation that all who live the life of the mind eagerly join. In this heady and sometimes intimidating realm, *Motion Sickness* aims to be a place of welcome.

The publishers of this volume aspire to enrich the intellectual life of California's Great Central Valley by providing a forum for CSU Stanislaus students to publish and to work at different aspects of this industry: both as writers submitting their own work for inclusion in the journal, and as editors preparing manuscripts for publication, communicating with writers, and building issues of a journal in an atmosphere of cooperative teamwork. The product resonates with the spirit of curiosity and speculation that characterizes academic life at Stanislaus State and its environs. *Motion Sickness* represents the collective powers of the students and English professors at our university. As such, the journal is a mirror reflecting our inner landscapes as well as the concerns and obsessions of the region and the intellectual climate in which we dwell.

In its mission to cultivate the scholarship of the literary essay, *Motion Sickness* follows in the tradition of its notable, and sometimes half-forgotten, predecessors at Stan State. Most recently, *Agasia: A Journal of Literary Chatter*, lived a brief online

life, emerging from and returning to virtual dust in 2015. Two years earlier, *The San Joaquin Valley Journal* took its turn inviting graduate students and others to submit for online publication their articles, reviews, and other non-fictional works with an emphasis on regional flavors and subject matter. In the early nineties, before the days of digital publishing, *The Leaning Tree*—named for the parallel rows of angled trees outside of the erstwhile home of the English Department in the Vasche Library—managed a few offprints featuring essays on rhetoric and literature mostly written by young professors and advanced graduate students. And as an outlet for the creative works of CSU Stanislaus students, our print journal *Penumbra* has been providing a lively forum for poetry and fiction, photography, fine art, and creative non-fiction since 1989. *Penumbra*, too, had a much lesser-known antecedent: *Between Sheets: A CSCS Magazine*. This modest, thoughtful little journal, published by the Department of English, Foreign Languages, and Philosophy, appeared in the '70s and persisted into the early 1980s. It featured charming and occasionally puerile black-and-white drawings, fiction, poetry, and drama—the creative output of local students and professors. The last issue I saw was from 1983, number 17. A chilling notice appears at the bottom of the final recto: “Because of increasing costs and budget cuts, we cannot accept manuscripts or graphics for future issues of *Between Sheets* until further notice.” The tinny institutional tone of that final statement echoes the sometimes sad plight of the humanities journal and the writers who depend on these platforms in academe. The aspirations of *Between Sheets* and its contributors became an easily deleted line on an expense sheet.

These journals that have faded into the history of CSU Stanislaus, whether they withered from lack of administrative funding or simply had run their course, should each one be considered a successful step in an ongoing project. Like the cohorts

of students who in the 1970s wrote for *Between Sheets* or in the 1990s published in *The Leaning Tree*, and so on, they were here for a time to “contribute a verse” and then gone, but the “powerful play goes on.” And what goes on into the future here in its iteration as *Motion Sickness* is the drive and desire to support local writers, to give space to both the academic literary essay and its creative writing kin. The former, of course, consumes much of the energy of students of English and literature. The analytical essay is the star of academic conferences and careers and the content of research databases like JSTOR and EBSCO. Gatherings of literary essays represent voices in critical dialogue that students in MA and PhD programs must learn to develop as they begin professional lives in academe, or in editing and publishing, or in virtually any career featuring professional writing—or simply as part of a rich, reflective life which includes an informed appreciation of poetry, film, drama, and fiction. The texts that manage to find their way into *Motion Sickness* will populate a beautiful hard-copy edition created by savvy students working in the service of the English club, Warrior Bookworms & Wordsmiths, a group of dedicated scholars-in-becoming. Overhead is low. Determination, teamwork, ingenuity, and elbow-grease are our capital. The literary conversation is our commitment.

An ongoing literary conversation implies a community, and *Motion Sickness* was in fact born of a community event; the journal comprises several student essays garnered from the first annual Media in Full Bloom conference at Stanislaus State University. The inaugural meeting took place on Friday, March 13th, at the Faculty Development Center. Funded by a grant from the division of Faculty Affairs and organized by the English club, the one-day conference featured five panels and sixteen presenters from Stanislaus State and other institutions in the region. Emeritus Professor Arnold Schmidt, who in his time developed and taught the first film courses in the English curriculum, delivered the keynote address, “Transmedia, Adaptation, & Pedagogy.” At the end

of the day, PhD candidate and Stan State alumnus Nathan Wilke made introductory remarks on *Friday the 13th* and the proliferation of the slasher film, and as the sun began to sink, those brave conference attendees left standing took their seats to enjoy a screening of this early, influential horror film. For most of the student participants, Media in Full Bloom signaled an academic milestone, their first conference presentation. In many cases, proud family members and other supporters joined the audience to bear witness to the moment. And, of course, the next step for conference participants is submitting their conference papers for publication. That's the cue for *Motion Sickness* to come on stage.

From the sixteen presentations during the conference, seven essays are included here, a vibrant selection of original thinking and careful scholarship to offer to our first readers, who are invited to savor the interplay between the journal's title, *Motion Sickness*, and the title of the conference from which it derives, Media in Full Bloom. A bloom suggests flourishing, but it can also describe an overabundance (for example, an algae bloom is a type of proliferation that disrupts and can degrade an ecosystem). *Motion Sickness* reads as the embodied consequence of Media in Full Bloom: when media proliferate, accelerate, and circulate beyond our ability to orient ourselves within them, those who strive to maintain a sense of individual agency and authenticity need help navigating the deluge of sights and sounds that constitute our being-in-the-world. "Motion Sickness" describes a conceptual bridge spanning the conference and the proceedings volume. The essays contained herein aim to help readers make sense of the media voices, images, and memes that continually wash over us all, inducing, at times, uncertainty and existential nausea. To the seven scholars whose work appears in this inaugural collection of media-inspired essays, thank you for contributing a verse to the pullulating intellectual flora of Stanislaus State University.

Hitchcock's Nosedives: The Subtexts of Alfred Hitchcock's Cinematic Falls

Schuyler Becker

From the villain of *Saboteur* (1942) clinging to the apex of the Statue of Liberty to the recognizable “Vertigo Shot,” now known as the “dolly zoom” film technique, Alfred Hitchcock’s filmography has obsessively delineated elements of acrophobia and basophobia. Sometimes the audience is privy to a character on the precipice of a great fall, such as when Mrs. de Winter and Mrs. Danvers grapple at the second-story window of the Manderley Estate; other times the audience recognizes the “cliffhanger” trope made literal in a character hanging from a great height, such as in *Rear Window* (1954); at times, the audience explores heights in culminating action of the fall itself: the moment when Arbogast topples down the stairs in *Psycho* (1960) or Madeleine meets her foreseen fate in *Vertigo* (1958). Hitchcock’s masterful techniques provide the visual, cinematic language of bodily freefall. In the subtexts of Hitchcock’s falling scenes, there resides a multitude of moral and mythical subtexts, from existential crises and punishment to acts of heroism and self-discovery. The range of meaning for the fall as a symbol is endless: the fallen angel Lucifer is the ultimate symbol of degradation and depravity as a punishment for pride and a lust for power; Icarus flies too close to the sun, distracted by pleasure and hubris in a reflection of Fortune’s Wheel before a deadly plunge to the sea below; humans once convinced themselves that missing sailors had pushed the limits of discovery too far and fallen off the edge of the earth. Hitchcock bridges the gap between historic depictions of falling as a moral metaphor, and more modern falls as a necessary force of change. Focused on the force of the fall as a catalyst, Hitchcock curates dizzying and detailed cinematographic techniques to depict psychological metaphors within falling, subtexts of human hierarchies in the form of grappling duos, and the existential detachments and discoveries that coincide with a solitary freefall.

Perhaps the first technique in cinematography that arises with Hitchcock is the famous “vertigo shot,” which consists of an active “dolly zoom” technique. According to David Welton, “The

dolly zoom effect involves zooming while simultaneously using a dolly to move the camera. The result is a dizzying effect pioneered by Alfred Hitchcock in the bell tower scene in *Vertigo* (1958),” Scottie’s fear of heights plagues him so intensely that he’s unable to make it to Madeleine in time before she allegedly falls from the precipice (Welton). Such a technique places the audience in the shoes of those within the scene, allowing them to view all from the perspective of the protagonist’s eyes. Scottie’s fear of heights and falling is a fear that the audience is forced to experience vicariously through the vertigo shot and other film angles originating from a summit perspective. Hitchcock utilizes this same angle approach in *Psycho* (1960) when Arbogast is attacked by “mother” and topples down the stairs. Where *Vertigo* places stairwells as the central point for the camera, *Psycho* positions its central point in the background, with Arbogast’s shocked face and arms grasping at the air while he falls into the dolly zoom effect beneath him. Hitchcock’s methods of inducing a sense of pseudo-vertigo in his audiences are at the core of his aesthetics of falling. The fall is often far more than a mere physical act, but rather a result of crisis and discovery. The exterior must crumble to reveal the secrets within one’s psyche. The term “vertigo” itself originates from the Latin term *vertere*, meaning “to turn.” The origins of vertigo’s language are fitting for Hitchcock’s purposes, as the moment just before the climactic fall may be aptly described as a turning point—a moment that will forever mark a “before” and an “after,” from the mysteries soon to unravel before Scottie about Madeleine to the death of detective Arbogast as he nears the truth.

Hitchcock leans into dizzying effects that differ from the vertigo shot as well. In some instances of falling, the camera frame stays at rest in a wide shot, while the victim spins to their demise. In *Saboteur*, there are a few instances of character’s falling, such as a handcuffed Barry plunging into the river to escape from police (an intentional fall, but forced), but most notably is the apotheosis of the film: the great fall of the villain named Fry from America’s most

famous monument. The fall scene of Fry is portrayed as follows: a brief grappling ensues between Barry and Fry before Fry topples over the side of the Statue of Liberty's torch, followed by a zoomed-in shot of his hands gripping the edge with muted audio creating a dissonance between the intensity of the scene and the finality of what is about to occur. Close-up shots of Barry and Fry's faces alternate with angles from Barry's point-of-view looking down at Fry, then the frame cuts from a silent zoom-in of Fry's sleeve slowly tearing at the seams to a zoomed-out image of the Statue from a slightly lower angle. The scene finally culminates in Fry falling in a rotational pattern-body pinwheeling as the steady camera looks down on him; in that moment, the symbol of the Nazi saboteur being ejected from Lady Liberty presents a symbol of the fall of the third Reich. Fry's fall also delivers a broader message of heroism winning out over villainy. The thing to be feared is simply that which is dizzying to witness, whether that be a dangerous drop or an enemy meeting their fate. The visual of villainy falling from a symbol of the American Dream is also a testament to the disillusionment from that Dream with the hardship of two world wars, and perhaps even the lingering existential crisis from the Great Depression. Fry's death serves as a glimpse into the hopefulness of heroism and an unmasking of the realities of warfare and moral opposition, as Barry attempts to save Fry as an act of grace, although he ultimately fails.

A similar demise of a villain, with aligned filming techniques, can be found in *North by Northwest* (1959). In fact, *North by Northwest* also parallels *Saboteur* in its use of a famous monument as the backdrop for the final standoff scene with the villains and its cliffhanger imagery with a character, or in the case of *North by Northwest* the two main heroes and lovers, hanging on by their fingertips. In this climactic scene, the backdrop is Mount Rushmore—a testament to heroism's station in a hierarchical order according to American History. The heroes manage to eject their oppressors from the precipice in *North by Northwest* while

clambering atop the grandiose symbol of patriotism and stability. Hitchcock employs the use of lower camera angles as the characters descend the faces of Mount Rushmore in alternation with wide shots displaying full bodies and the landscape, as well as the opposite angle of looking down as one of the villains turns over in a fall to the forest below. For the fall of another villain in the showdown, Hitchcock chooses a subtler approach to displaying the fall as the camera follows a zoomed-in shot of his shoe tipping over before his body follows off the edge. *Rear Window* also features a still frame with the victim falling backwards from the foreground, though in that film it isn't the villain falling but our main character, Jeff. More akin to Arbogast in *Psycho*, Jeff takes up the central space in the frame, falling backwards to meet the ground. However, in *Rear Window* Hitchcock elects not to mimic the dizzying effect of a dolly zoom but rather, allows Jeff to fall further away and out of focus as he seems to float to the ground. This scene might be placed in juxtaposition with a scene like Fry's fall in *Saboteur* in that the sympathetic character seems bound to be saved by luck as a reward for good virtue. Thus, Hitchcock's varying depictions of falling contain subliminal messaging regarding the good or immoral character of the victim.

No less important than camera placement and movement, framing is integral to Hitchcockian scenes involving falling, at least according to Tom Gunning. Gunning claims that "especially when [Hitchcock] uses an interior compositional frame, such as a window or a doorway, within the larger film frame," one can deduce a reoccurring pattern of frames representing "entrapment of characters" (Gunning 14). It is vital to not disregard the intentionality of Hitchcock's frames in his fall scenes. A prime example is Jeff's fall in *Rear Window* presenting a subtext of freedom in the fall—not just freedom from the villain's clawing reach, but freedom from the unfulfilled self Jeff had been inhabiting. Another example is in *Shadow of a Doubt* (1943), with Niece Charlie and Uncle Charlie struggling with one another before

Uncle Charlie, the villain, loses the battle; the scene is accompanied by the use of trains as a frame. The camera pans over to a side angle with two trains serving as dual vertical edges to the frame as Uncle Charlie falls off the one train and onto the tracks of its parallel counterpart. As he falls back, his arms windmilling, and under the path of the oncoming train, there is an overlay of couples dancing the “merry widow waltz” over the image of the tracks, thus completing the *mise en scène* and bringing the film full circle as Uncle Charlie is the “merry widow killer.” One of Hitchcock’s earliest depictions of falling is a snapshot clip of a villain rolling off a roof in *The Man Who Knew Too Much*. After having taken the McKenna’s child hostage at the end of the 1934 film, the villains end up on the roof with their kidnapped victim until one of the perpetrators is shot by Mrs. McKenna and rolls off the roof.

Hitchcock speeds up the scene, resulting in a quick tumble followed by a fast-motion crowd below in a thrilling climax. The scene is rather like a landscape painting in that it frames the fall victim within the broader surroundings. In the 1956 version of *The Man Who Knew Too Much*, Hitchcock opts for a minimized falling scene, with the villain tumbling down the stairs instead of gunned down from a rooftop, thus reducing the scope of the scene, yet still maintaining the surrounding setting as a frame for the fall.

In the “Don’t Look Behind You” episode of *The Alfred Hitchcock Hour*, Harold proclaims, “Sane, insane, it’s all a matter of balance. Haven’t any of you ever felt that when you were terribly tired or worried sick about something that keeping your sanity was like walking a tightrope stretched across a great chasm and that, if the slightest thing went wrong, you’d topple off and never stop falling?” Harold’s philosophical contemplation is a foreshadowing of his eventual fall off that tightrope, spiraling out of his mind and attempting to kill Daphne “out of love.” Dave, after saving Daphne, observed that “jealousy unbalanced [Harold’s] mind.” Hitchcock’s endeavors in the psychological thriller genre are legendary, and it’s not quite a thriller until someone loses their mind a bit—whether that is losing their grip on the precipice of reality, rationality, or

some combination of the two. For Harold, his obsession with Daphne, mingled with his jealousy of her feelings for Dave, results in a fall from grace in her eyes: a transition from being her protector to her predator. A similar fall from heroism occurs in *Shadow of a Doubt*, when Niece Charlie must come to terms with the murderous identity of her beloved Uncle Charlie, after whom she had been named. Before his literal fall onto the train tracks, Uncle Charlie must first fall out of his namesake's benevolent eyes. In *Psycho*, the psychological symbolism of a fall from sanity merges with a hierarchical power dynamic, as the weaker elements of Norman's identity (the ego and id) give in to the dominant superego identity of "Mother" taking control and seeking only its own survival.

The image of grappling duos contains subtexts of power hierarchies and, similar to the moment before a great fall, an impending sense of danger or finality. Just as one grappler must fall at the hands of another, the scales of power will inevitably grant imbalanced favorability. No stasis of class, control, or reputation is possible for long in a state of conflict. In *Rebecca*, the audience is made privy to a tilting of the scales as the perceived superior in the class hierarchy, the lady of the estate, Mrs. de Winter, is placed on the verge of a plunge when Mrs. Danvers grapples with her at the second-story window of Manderley. This scene is perhaps one of the most intense moments in the entirety of the story, as Mrs. Danvers attempts to cajole the seemingly timid narrator into leaping out the window, thereby becoming another Mrs. de Winter ghost to haunt the estate. That moment may be one of the pivotal transition points that reveals the mettle of Mrs. de Winter, as curiosity wins out over devastation. Such a scene presents a thought-provoking visual of fortune and the fickleness of power dynamics as Mrs. de Winter overcomes the forces seeking to oppress her, or "knock her down." Some other instances of grappling duos in Alfred Hitchcock's films include: Niece and Uncle Charlie, mirror images of one another, battling it out between the similarly doubled trains in *Shadow of a Doubt* or Barry

and Fry struggling over the detonation button in *Saboteur* in a dichotomy of saboteur vs. framed saboteur, with Barry dominating in their individualized power dynamic; such a hierarchy is reaffirmed when Barry is situated above Fry on the Statue of Liberty, reaching down in an attempt to bridge their gap. Another example of a hierarchically different grappling duo is Jeff and Lars Thorwald in *Rear Window*. At the conclusion of the film, Lars provokes Jeff to fall out the window as a final (unsuccessful) attempt at regaining control over the narrative and maintaining his place as a mastermind. After the protagonist falls, *Rear Window* comes full circle with Jeff yet again winding up in a wheelchair with not one, but now two broken legs. Though it is a humorous ending and a representation of Jeff and Lisa's lives converging, the film's epilogue sequence also may be interpreted as a clever way of showing that the hero lives on, reset at the starting line for the next adventure.

At its core, the cinema of falling offers viewers an existential opportunity to reflect on their own sense of self and role within a larger social sphere. Randall Spinks observes the following in *Vertigo*:

By the end of the opening rooftop chase, Scottie is in acute existential crisis. He dangles by his fingers from a sagging rain gutter some ten floors above an alley. His police colleague has just plunged to his death in a heroic but foolish attempt at an impossible rescue. The subjective shot of his partner's body sprawled below explains the immediate cause of Scottie's subsequent guilt. People below stream into the alley to inspect the dead officer; no one looks up toward Scottie in his precarious isolation. He survives only to become a cog in another mechanism, whereby Scottie himself obsesses over rescuing a woman beyond his reach. (Spinks 15-16)

The image of the man hanging on by his fingertips brings to life the "cliffhanger" trope for audiences, evoking the uncertainty of future events and having a destabilizing effect on the viewer. Similarly, in

Rear Window, as Jeff hangs from the edge of the windowsill, it is unknown whether good or evil will prevail. The precarity of the moment forces audience members to reflect on why they desire the hero to win—or why not. Audiences may also learn from those instances in which they are able to explore heights in the final culminating action of the fall itself, such as the moment when Arbogast topples down the stairs in *Psycho*. In such scenes, the viewer transitions from voyeur to witness. Thus, Hitchcock’s “nosedives” serve as a fall for audiences as well: a fall through the screen and a fall from detachment. No longer are viewers allowed to be passive consumers, but they are forced into captivity. The visual intensity of a fall as depicted by Hitchcock is rife with metaphorical meaning pertaining to falls from grace, spinning out of control within the psyche, losing one’s grasp on power, and descending from an invisible apotheosis, whether that be a force of domination or morality. Such falls evoke the following reflection: are audiences facing a great precipice in their lives as well? Where does each consumer stand in the hierarchy between good and evil forces? Is falling a catalyst for change or finality, and how should that guide the way one thinks and takes action? Alfred Hitchcock’s toppling terrors and plummeting heroes present those questions and more for viewers, while on the surface all are left to simply embrace the fall.

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Marketing Shakespeare to Gen Z: Multimodal Pedagogy and the Reimagining of Canonical Literature

Nic DeLoach

As the cornerstone of early modern English literature and the English literary canon, Shakespeare has long occupied a central role in the classroom. Yet his continued presence does not automatically produce student engagement. For many Gen Z students, Shakespeare can seem distant from contemporary life because of the difficulty of the language, the historical settings, and text-centered pedagogical approaches that often begin with close reading, annotation, and discussion of the printed play before moving into performance or adaptation. This creates an important instructional challenge: how can educators make Shakespeare feel relevant without reducing the complexity of the original works? One answer is to use technology not as a replacement for Shakespeare, but as a bridge between the canonical text and the media environments students already understand.

In this sense, “marketing” Shakespeare does not mean simplifying the plays into entertainment or treating them as products detached from literary study. Instead, marketing means framing a play for a specific audience through selective emphasis, genre, tone, image, sound, design, and persuasion. A trailer or promotional poster does not merely advertise a play; it interprets the play by deciding what matters most and how an audience should encounter it. Multimedia assignments therefore do not make Shakespeare less literary. They ask students to turn close reading into public interpretation. By creating trailers, promotional posters, or other visual campaigns, students must make deliberate choices about character, conflict, tone, audience, performance, and evidence. In this way, multimedia composition offers a forward-looking, student-centered pedagogy for teaching canonical literature because it transforms close reading and performance into acts of digital interpretation.

In an undergraduate section of Shakespeare at Stan State, my own group’s project on *Henry IV, Part I* demonstrates this

process. Rather than presenting the play primarily as a royal history centered on Prince Hal's political development, our poster and trailer shifted attention toward Falstaff. We used the Boar's Head Tavern, period-appropriate costumes, and a heroic visual framing from Falstaff's perspective to market the play as comic, exaggerated, and character-driven. This decision was not only decorative. It was interpretive. By centering Falstaff, we implicitly argued that even though he is not the political hero of the play, he often becomes its theatrical and comic center of gravity. The poster and trailer therefore made visible what an essay might explain in prose: that the meaning of a Shakespeare play changes depending on whose perspective is emphasized, what setting is foregrounded, and what emotional response the audience is invited to have.

This kind of adaptation belongs to a much longer cultural history. Douglas Lanier argues that modern understandings of Shakespeare have been shaped not only by classrooms and theaters, but also by films, television, comics, advertising, and other forms of popular culture (1-20). From this perspective, asking students to translate Shakespeare into trailers or posters does not remove the plays from serious study. Instead, it places students within Shakespeare's continuing history of adaptation, circulation, and reinvention. The classroom project becomes one more way of asking how Shakespeare continues to mean something in new cultural moments.

Julie Sanders's work on adaptation and appropriation also helps explain why this transformation matters. Adaptation is not simply copying an original text into a new form; it involves selection, revision, emphasis, and reinterpretation (24, 25). When students transform a Shakespeare scene into a trailer or poster, they must decide what to preserve, what to omit, what to center, and how to reshape the work for a new audience. Those decisions require analysis. A multimedia project is therefore not a lesser

substitute for reading Shakespeare. It is a way of studying how Shakespeare can be remade while still remaining connected to the original play.

A key reason this approach works for Gen Z is that young adults often process texts through connections with other media. Dr. Jocelyn A. Chadwick, writing for the Folger Shakespeare Library, observes that Gen Z students frequently relate canonical texts to “TV, movies, songs, even advertisements” and that this process reflects their critical thinking and ability “to create new comprehension pathways” (Chadwick). This insight challenges the assumption that students who connect Shakespeare to popular media are avoiding serious analysis. Those connections can become a productive way into the text. When students compare a Shakespeare play to a movie trailer, poster, advertisement, or social media campaign, they are thinking about genre, persuasion, image, sound, character, and narrative structure. Rather than interpreting the text in isolation, they are using the language of contemporary media to arrive at literary understanding.

However, this approach should not assume that all Gen Z students are automatically fluent with digital tools or that technology alone produces engagement. The value of multimedia pedagogy comes from structure, not novelty. Students need to be taught how media choices shape meaning. They also need to remain accountable to the Shakespearean text. This is where the New London Group’s theory of multiliteracies becomes useful. The New London Group argues that contemporary literacy must account for multiple communication channels and changing social environments, not just traditional print-based reading and writing (60). A Shakespeare trailer or poster fits within this broader model because it asks students to make meaning through language, image, sound, performance, layout, and design. Similarly, the National Council of Teachers of English argues that multimodal literacy should be part of English instruction because students increasingly read and compose through multiple modes of communication. A multimedia

Shakespeare assignment therefore responds to how students already encounter meaning in the world while still requiring careful attention to literary form and textual evidence.

Gunther Kress's theory of multimodality strengthens this point because it treats communication as something that happens through many modes, not language alone. In a Shakespeare classroom, this matters because the plays themselves already depend on more than words on a page. Voice, gesture, movement, space, costume, and timing all help create meaning in performance. Multimedia projects allow students to translate those theatrical modes into digital forms such as framing, editing, sound, typography, and visual composition. In doing so, students learn that meaning is made through relationships among modes, not through text alone.

This does not mean that traditional methods should disappear. Shakespeare still benefits from close reading, group discussion, and live performance. In fact, technology is most effective when it is integrated with these older methods. Ayanna Thompson and Laura Turchi argue that Shakespeare instruction should help students gain facility with complex texts by combining collaborative classroom practices with independent critical analysis. Their model is especially useful for a digital Shakespeare project because they describe twenty-first century Shakespeare pedagogy as one that asks students to read, write, speak, listen, view, create, and perform in order to understand complex texts (1–3). In this sense, trailers and posters are not distractions from literary study. They become structured learning activities through which students practice interpretation, performance, design, collaboration, and audience awareness.

Other performance-based Shakespeare pedagogies make the same point. In *Shakespeare Set Free*, Peggy O'Brien and her coauthors emphasize that students learn Shakespeare most effectively by doing Shakespeare (O'Brien et al.). This active pedagogy asks students to speak lines aloud, stage scenes, test

interpretive choices, and experience the plays as dramatic events rather than static texts. A multimedia Shakespeare project builds on this performance tradition. It does not replace embodied work with technology; it extends performance into another medium by asking students to consider camera angles, visual focus, music, editing, and audience response.

A strong multimedia assignment should therefore move through stages: close reading, performance, design, and reflection. First, students need to understand the plot, language, and character relationships of the play. Group readings and scene breakdowns help students identify major conflicts, tones, and significant lines. In-class discussion allows them to test interpretations, clarify confusing passages, and consider how different choices shape meaning. Live performance is equally important because Shakespeare's plays were written for the stage, not only for silent reading. When students act out scenes, they often discover meaning through gesture, tone, pacing, and movement that may not be obvious on the page. Performance reminds students that Shakespeare is not simply literature to be analyzed, but drama meant to be embodied.

Once students have read, discussed, and performed scenes, they are better prepared to transform their interpretation into an adaptation. A movie trailer requires students to decide which scenes create suspense, which lines are memorable, what tone the play should have, and how the audience should feel. A promotional poster requires them to think visually: which character should dominate the design? What symbols represent the play's central conflict? Should the poster look tragic, comic, historical, romantic, or political? These questions are not separate from literary interpretation. They force students to decide what the play is truly about and how that meaning can be communicated to a modern audience.

Anderson and Krathwohl's revision of Bloom's taxonomy is useful here because it frames learning as a movement from remembering and understanding toward analyzing, evaluating, and

creating (66–68). A multimedia Shakespeare project asks students to move through those stages. Students must understand the play, analyze its conflicts and characters, evaluate which elements matter most for a contemporary audience, and create a new interpretive product. In this way, a multimedia Shakespeare assignment does not move away from literary study. Instead, it expands the forms through which literary understanding can be demonstrated.

Thompson and Turchi also discuss the value of writing and thinking in response to film trailers and other digital materials. They argue that film trailers can help students practice close viewing by asking them to observe interpretive details and debate the choices made in a performance or adaptation (127). This supports the use of student-created trailers because the process asks students to make those interpretive choices themselves. When students decide which scenes to include, how to cast characters, what images to emphasize, and how to frame the tone of the play, they move beyond surface-level reactions to costumes or actors and begin to understand performance as interpretation (127–28). A Shakespeare trailer therefore becomes a form of literary analysis: it requires students to articulate the relationship between the original text and the visual, sonic, and dramatic choices they make.

The interpretive value of this approach becomes clearer through my group's *Henry IV, Part I* project. Our poster was made from a still of our movie trailer. We included period-appropriate costuming, used the Boar's Head Tavern as the setting, and presented the story as a heroic narrative from Falstaff's perspective. In a traditional reading, Prince Hal moves between the tavern world of Falstaff and the political world of his father, King Henry IV, before eventually proving himself in battle. By shifting the focus to Falstaff, the poster markets the play less as a royal history and more as a character-driven story centered on humor, exaggeration, and self-mythology.

This shift demonstrates the interpretive power of promotional design. A poster does not simply announce a play; it

frames the play for an audience. If Falstaff is centered visually, then viewers may expect the story to be comic, bold, and shaped by his personality. If Prince Hal becomes almost a prop in Falstaff's story, then the poster reverses the usual hierarchy between the characters. This was not a random creative decision. It reflected a particular reading of the play, one that recognizes Falstaff's enormous theatrical presence. Even when he is not the political center of the story, he often dominates the audience's attention. By presenting *Henry IV, Part I* from Falstaff's perspective, my group attempted to capture the way a supporting character can become the emotional and comic center of a play.

The Boar's Head Tavern setting also mattered. The tavern represents the social world of Falstaff and Hal: disorderly, comic, performative, and removed from the formal responsibilities of the court. Choosing this location visually emphasized the play's contrast between public duty and private pleasure. It also made the poster more accessible because a tavern setting feels immediate and theatrical. Audiences can quickly understand it as a place of friendship, mischief, drinking, storytelling, and performance. Period-appropriate costuming further connected the project to the historical world of the play. Even though my group used modern design tools, the costumes helped preserve a connection to Shakespeare's setting and atmosphere. The result was a hybrid product: historically aware but digitally produced, rooted in the play but designed for a contemporary viewer.

This example shows why teaching Shakespeare through multimedia matters. A group that presents *Henry IV, Part I* through Falstaff is not simply making the play more entertaining; it is making an argument about the play's center of gravity. The design choices reveal an interpretation: Falstaff may not be the political hero of the history play, but he is often its comic and theatrical force. Centering him in the poster asks an audience to see the play differently. In this way, multimedia assignments make literary interpretation visible. An essay explains an argument through prose, but a poster or trailer

can communicate an argument through image, focus, color, setting, sound, and pacing. Students learn that analysis is not only something written after reading; it is something built into every creative choice.

This approach also develops digital and media literacy.

Students learn not only how to use software, but how to communicate meaning through digital media. They must consider how design choices affect perception. A dark color palette may suggest tragedy or danger. Fast cuts may create excitement or anxiety. A particular font may suggest historical drama, horror, comedy, or romance. These choices teach students that media is constructed. Just as Shakespeare uses language, metaphor, rhythm, and dramatic structure to shape meaning, digital creators use editing, framing, image, and sound. By working with these tools, students become more aware of how media influences audiences. This is an important skill beyond the Shakespeare classroom because students encounter digital persuasion constantly in advertising, entertainment, politics, and social media.

The significance of this approach therefore extends beyond Shakespeare. Students are not only learning a canonical text; they are learning how meaning is made across different forms of communication. A font, color palette, camera angle, or musical cue can shape an audience's response just as deliberately as a metaphor or soliloquy can shape a reader's interpretation. A Shakespeare multimedia project therefore also teaches media literacy. It helps students recognize that the images, videos, advertisements, and online content they encounter every day are constructed through choices that persuade, emphasize, omit, and frame. Teaching Shakespeare through multimedia connects literary analysis to the broader interpretive demands of twenty-first century life.

However, multimedia projects also have limitations. One challenge is the learning curve of professional digital editing and design tools. In my own group, only two members had any experience with video editing software, and neither of us had used the assigned editing platform before. Although we scheduled an

appointment with the technology department and received a demonstration, our newness to the software made post-production complicated. I eventually offered to trim the raw video and create a background for our tavern setting before sending the project to another group member for sound effects and text. This work was far more difficult than expected and required tutorials, discussion boards, trial and error, and significant time.

This experience revealed that digital assignments require scaffolding. If students spend too much time struggling with software, the technology may distract from the literary purpose of the assignment. For that reason, a short crash course would be useful before students begin production. Instructors might provide tutorials, templates, sample projects, or guided practice sessions. The goal is not to turn every student into a professional designer or editor, but to give them enough technical confidence to communicate their interpretations effectively. A higher-education case study on digital creativity with Adobe products supports the idea that students can use structured digital projects to generate ideas, innovate, and circulate their work (Adobe). However, the value of these projects does not come from the software itself. It comes from the way the assignment is designed. Digital creativity in the classroom does not happen simply because students are given access to a platform. It happens when projects are connected to course goals, textual evidence, collaboration, and reflection.

Time is another major challenge. Multimedia projects often take much longer than expected, especially during post-production. Editing video, adjusting images, arranging text, and revising a design all require patience. Students may underestimate how much work is involved after filming or drafting the basic concept. To address this issue, instructors should build in multiple stages: proposal, storyboard or mock-up, rough cut or draft, peer feedback, revision, and final reflection. This structure would make the project more manageable and would prevent students from saving too much work for the end. It would also reinforce the idea that creative work is a

process rather than a single product.

Collaboration can also be difficult. In my group, the production of the trailer was challenging because we were fragmented and often disagreed over direction, including costuming, setting, and scene choice. We had no solid leadership structure, and this affected the production process. Although not completely intentional, my role as Prince Hal became less active and more of a background presence. Still, this decentralization also created an unexpected interpretation: the trailer and final performance became a narrative with Falstaff at the center. This shows both the difficulty and the value of collaboration. Group projects require shared vision, communication, and fair distribution of labor, but they can also produce interpretations that individual students might not have discovered alone. Clear role assignments could help. For example, one student might serve as project manager, another as editor, another as designer, another as researcher, and another as scriptwriter, with all students taking on some role in performance. Regular check-ins between students and instructors can ensure that the group remains cohesive.

Because creative assignments can easily become focused on polish or entertainment, they should include written reflection. Thompson and Turchi warn that creative and multimodal assignments are most valuable when they demonstrate students' facility with complex texts and require students to think analytically about the original play and the changes they make (134). This distinction is important for evaluating multimedia Shakespeare projects. A trailer or poster should not be graded only for effort, polish, humor, or entertainment value. It should be assessed according to how well it shows understanding of Shakespeare's language, character relationships, themes, genre, and performance possibilities. A written reflection might ask students to explain why they emphasized certain characters, why they chose particular settings or visual symbols, and how their design choices shape audience expectations. This would ensure that the project remains

analytically grounded.

A practical version of this assignment could be organized as a short teaching module titled “Marketing Shakespeare to Gen Z.” First, students would complete a close reading of a key scene from a play such as *Henry IV, Part I*, identifying major conflicts, character relationships, tone, and significant lines. Second, students would perform the scene in small groups, experimenting with gesture, pacing, voice, and emphasis. Third, the class would discuss how performance choices change interpretation. Fourth, students would examine examples of posters or trailers and identify how image, sound, color, typography, and editing shape audience expectations. Fifth, student groups would create either a promotional poster or a short trailer that markets the play to a Gen Z audience. Finally, each group would submit a written reflection explaining how its creative choices connect to the original text.

The learning goals for this module would be literary interpretation, performance awareness, collaboration, multimodal composition, and audience analysis. These goals could be assessed through a rubric with six categories: textual understanding, interpretive focus, supporting evidence, design choices, collaboration, and written reflection. Textual understanding would measure the accuracy of the project’s representation of the play’s characters, conflicts, and themes. Interpretive focus would address whether the poster or trailer presents a clear argument about the play. Supporting evidence would consider how effectively the group’s creative choices connect to specific lines, scenes, or motifs. Design choices would assess the use of image, sound, editing, typography, or composition to shape audience response. Collaboration would account for shared responsibility, communication, and group organization. Finally, the written reflection would require students to explain how their creative product interprets Shakespeare’s text.

Ultimately, technology can make Shakespeare more marketable to Gen Z because it allows students to encounter the plays through familiar media forms while still engaging in serious interpretation. Movie trailers and promotional posters transform Shakespeare into something visual, collaborative, and

audience-centered. They help students see that the plays are not frozen in time, but capable of being adapted for new cultural moments. At the same time, technology should not replace close reading, discussion, or performance. The most effective approach combines traditional Shakespeare instruction with digital creativity. When students read scenes, perform them, discuss them, and then redesign them for a contemporary audience, they gain a fuller understanding of both the text and its possibilities.

The larger significance of teaching Shakespeare this way is that it prepares students to interpret both literature and media more critically. Shakespeare remains valuable not only because his plays are historically important, but because they continue to teach students how language, performance, identity, power, and audience shape meaning. A multimedia assignment makes those lessons visible. When students transform a scene into a trailer or poster, they learn that interpretation is always a set of choices: what to emphasize, what to omit, whose perspective to center, and how to move an audience. These are literary skills, but they are also twenty-first century communication skills.

A multimedia-led approach also gives students practical skills wherein they learn digital design, editing, collaboration, project management, and audience awareness. More importantly, they learn that interpretation can take many forms. An essay interprets through argument; a performance interprets through voice and movement; a trailer interprets through pacing and sound; a poster interprets through image and design. All these forms can reveal something meaningful about Shakespeare. For Gen Z students, who already live in a world shaped by media, this approach makes Shakespeare not less literary, but more alive.

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Green Screen and the Shakespearean Ideal

Kevin Gasaway

The average amateur video project often stumbles on the first step in production: having a completed script. In fact, according to most insider gossip many professional blockbuster Hollywood endeavors also balk out of the gate because of unwritten endings and must scramble for reshoots to “finish” the story. Luckily when students wish to voyage into the “do it yourself” field of stage craft they already have a finely aged and fully crowd-pleasing screenplay penned by the master Bard himself, and so suffer though none of the pesky script-writing decisions that might need to be made otherwise.

Indeed, with a simple green screen and a few visual ideas a small room can be transformed into Falstaff’s tavern; with a few mouse clicks, a light breaks through yonder window; adjust a few simple sliders and the grand majesty of Denmark can be achieved. From the advent of home film and VHS it was certainly possible to capture a live performance anywhere at any time, but what has dawned in the digital age is the ability to truly finish it, post-produce and refine it, disseminate and stream it virally, all at a relatively miniscule cost and knowledge level. A film by any other name...

The existing shared knowledge the students have of Shakespeare and other well-studied texts means that no brain power need be spent on the lines or stories themselves. This allows creativity to become king: the “how” becomes the big question instead of the “what.” Everyone knows that Hamlet dithers and procrastinates, that Othello is jealous, and that Romeo and Juliet are over the moon in love, but with a wealth of technology and studio properties at their disposal, how are students going to bring these texts to life? Many stage and Hollywood productions have found the freedom to use the bones of a sonnet (such as the one shared by Romeo and Juliet when they first meet at the Capulet ball) and dress it up with their own unique flesh of choice. Students as well as professional directors have the luxury of concentrating on backgrounds, acting, and costumes while the words themselves are

set (but students with a flair for rebellion can even switch those up, thereby offering new meanings, contexts, or usage). “The play’s the thing” in a nutshell: they now dwell in “an undiscovered country” of film production.

But now that creativity is King? Heavy lies that crown on the head of the not-so-media-savvy student. The student, finally liberated, puffed-up with pride, can now do anything anywhere with digital tools; the end result of such hubris may indeed represent a much higher bar to clear: in this heady realm, mistakes are more noticeable, audio quality more relevant, graphical mismatches more glaring. Heading into hyper-resolutions means the old cover-ups can be obvious, the workarounds non-seamless. Forgiveness and a steady guiding hand from a friendly technician or one of his acolytes is almost always necessary since neither these things nor their solutions are self-evident. Since now a performance of the stage can be rendered down to just 1s and 0s, fledgling filmmakers are fortunate to find that help can be provided to nudge those digits into place. But as always, even during the days of Shakespeare: practice will make perfect, whether it be before, during, or after the play. To understand what can be done, a budding Branaugh or an emerging Olivier must first leap in and do it, then wrestle with the outcome: that is the true learning scenario. However, in this day and age a fortune need not be spent nor countless hours lost on the attempts, the redoes, and the many fixes that lead to a clean, final copy. A strong personality and a group of creatives to gather and organize the scenes and the scene-makers also won’t hurt as the chaotic outpourings of ideas and personalities lumber towards the goal line of a finished digital product.

Please bear in mind that production troubles will still rear their many ugly heads, like Hydra battling Hercules. Shakespeare in no way will automatically slay the beasts of inexperience, differing tastes or opinions or viewpoints, personality clashes. And most of all: scheduling. Ask any seasoned production manager and you’ll

hear that mastering logistics is half the battle—getting everyone to gather at a specific time and a place, for example. Nothing will ever replace a great location, but a student project is greatly simplified by being able to gather everyone in one controlled environment to film everything and being able to match it all back together afterwards on the computer in the quiet calmness of the studio during post-production.

A good summation of what the digital revolution brings to student video: at least it won't take as long to learn and do. To quote MacBeth, "If it were done when 'tis done, then 'twere well It were done quickly." Hopefully students' creative attempts at cinematic art end up a more positive experience than that of the unhappy Scottish thane!

Encouraging Empathy: The “Other” in BBC’s *Merlin*

Emily Shaw

BBC’s *Merlin* (2008-2012) is a purely fantasy television show that de-historicizes its adaptation of Arthurian legend while relying on audience knowledge of history, canon, and current events to make sense of its “Othering” of magic. In *Merlin*’s Camelot, magic and magic users are outlawed on pain of death and are cast as the minority; magical beings must hide their true identities for fear of persecution. Magic signifies the Other and represents various minority groups in modern-day society having to do with gender and queerness. *Merlin* alludes to real-life instances of Othering as a respectful nod to past events and to relate the show with the current world’s struggle with tolerance and empathy. *Merlin*’s implicit need for relevancy is crucial to the show’s purpose: if the audience relates to on-screen characters and connects themselves to aspects of the plot, viewers will empathize with the plights of those being Othered in the show. Arthurian legends are often conflated with morality tales and historically “came to be prescribed in social and pedagogical theory as a model for leading a virtuous and courageous life” (Lupack 433). *Merlin*’s creators likely chose the topic of Arthurian legend specifically to lend credence to the purpose of the show. I argue that BBC’s *Merlin* encourages the audience to empathize with its Othered characters in order to inspire empathy for Othered individuals in real life, thereby creating a more tolerant society overall. With *Merlin* being referred to as the living embodiment of magic throughout the series, he can also be understood to be the show’s absolute symbol of the Other. *Merlin*, then, not only provides a new perspective on Arthurian legend but also a glimpse into the lives of those who are Othered by society and can only hope for the world to change.

BBC’s *Merlin* represents the Othering of femininity. The three main villains of the show are all women so that the antagonists will strike fear into Camelot’s heart in more ways than

just magic. Rather, the purpose of the magical female villains is to play upon fears of subversive gender roles. Arthurian legend presents the feminine as only a supportive role to the masculine, with the female perspective only being necessary in the fact that women, indeed, exist (Heng 97). Geraldine Heng posits that women implicitly make their own power in Arthurian legend by taking matters into their own hands. While men have swords as weapons, women gain power “Through magic, a woman’s equivalent of a knight’s skill at arms, and a means of accomplishing a purpose by her own efforts” (112). Magic, then, might be viewed as inherently feminine in nature. The physical act of fighting, as often performed by the knights in *Merlin*, is definitely a masculine act. Even weaponry might be considered symbolic of the phallus for its purpose of penetrating the foe. In a world in which many women are not presented the opportunity to be on equal footing with men, magic presents the ability for a woman to surpass the strength of men. In *Merlin*, magic is greatly feared for its potential to subvert gender norms.

The three main antagonists of BBC’s *Merlin*—Nimueh, Morgause, and Morgana—are representative of the monstrous-feminine, or “what it is about woman that is shocking, terrifying, horrific, abject” (251). In *Merlin*, the monstrous-feminine is a woman who does not embrace her gender roles, intentionally or not, and thereby horrifies those who subscribe to the rules of heteropatriarchy (265). Nimueh is monsterized as the inspiration for the purge as Uther blames her for Queen Ygraine’s death. Morgause, on the other hand, was deemed as monstrous from birth, when she first showed signs of possessing magic and was viewed as a threat to social stability (Creed 253). Morgana is the overarching villainess of the series, but was originally loyal to Uther, Arthur, and Camelot as well as being kind-hearted and passionate about helping the people of her kingdom. While she

occasionally opposed Uther, it was never out of malice but concern that his actions or laws were unjustified or overly cruel. Uther's closed-mindedness casts the world into a binary: good versus evil, natural versus supernatural, non-magic versus magic. It's not until she understands that she has magic that Morgana becomes terrified of being found out and persecuted by her own caretakers. This terror causes Morgana to completely diverge from Uther and Arthur, growing resentful of everyone in Camelot because she believes they would try to kill her as soon as they found out about her magic. When she discovers that she is Uther's daughter and firstborn child, though illegitimate, Morgana's fear begins to turn to conquest, believing that she has more of a claim to the throne than Arthur and can use her position as queen to free magic. Morgana's magic is only revealed and viewed as monstrous when she attempts to overthrow Uther and Arthur in a coup ("The Coming of Arthur: Part One"). Though she is inevitably feared by Camelot, Morgana also monsterizes herself by becoming the epitome of the "evil magic user"—violent, merciless, and power-hungry. Morgana's character arc from protagonist to antagonist is representative of the fear that comes with suddenly being labeled as the Other and attempting to survive in a world that preys on her downfall. Morgana's intentions become imbued with ambition for power and the throne over time, but her main goal is to free magic, free magic users, and free herself. Her intentions are pure, but her methods are warped by ambition and fear.

Though Merlin is a male character, he does embody many stereotypical features of female gender norms, even more so than the show's own female main characters. Merlin is a caring, loyal person to a fault, going out of his way to help others even when it's to his own detriment. Merlin is a servant to King Arthur, which involves him performing many domestically effeminate tasks like cleaning, sewing, and cooking. Merlin is also one of few main characters who is unable or unwilling to change or rise out of his position, implying that the implicit femininity of his role is

non-optional. Whereas even the female characters have some ability with weapons and fighting, Merlin has no physical capabilities whatsoever and generally opts to hide behind trees during fight scenes in order to use his magic without being noticed. While hiding in order to use magic is a necessity, Merlin never learns to physically fight nor is he shown to possess any form of the physical strength that is typical of masculinity. Merlin is portrayed as quite the feminine character, and it's clear that the only way he can maintain equivalent power with other male characters is through his magic. Because he can't reveal his magic, however, he is often placed below other male characters in terms of ability, strength, and respect. Though the show uses this femininity as a point of humor against Merlin, Barbara Creed's theory dictates that "the monstrous is produced at the border which separates those who take up their proper gender roles from those who do not" (253); in other words, if anyone who associates magic with the monstrous were to discover and equate Merlin's femininity with his magic, he would surely be persecuted and executed.

Despite much speculation amongst fans about the presence of queerness in *Merlin*, few critics perform queer interpretations of the show. It's necessary to present a queer analysis of any given media, especially one as implicitly queer as *Merlin*, for the chance to provide representation in the media for those struggling with their own identities. The creators of *Merlin* certainly leave enough room for interpretation into various characters' queer identities, but those with magic provide a much more convincing case. Judith Butler describes conformance to heteronormativity as "the tacit collective agreement to perform, produce, and sustain... and the punishments that attend not agreeing to believe in them; the construction 'compels' our belief in its necessity and naturalness" (2387).

Although *Merlin* does not explicitly discuss queerness, the portrayal of magic as a deviant characteristic that must be hidden for survival is very similar to how queer theory depicts

transgressive identities. Magic is presented as something that people are born with rather than something willingly chosen. People can study the Old Religion for years and be unable to perform its feats without a natural affinity for magic. Magic, like queerness, is a natural phenomenon, and its presence in someone's identity is beyond mortal control. The fact that magic users also have to hide their identity for fear of persecution is an unfortunate commonality in the queer community. With regards to both magic and queerness, non-normatives must conceal crucial aspects of themselves and attempt to pass and conform according to social norms for survival.

The show consistently follows three magic users in Camelot: Gaius, Morgana, and Merlin. Gaius is the only magic user whom Uther purposefully allowed to survive the purge. Gaius is a loyal member of Camelot's court, the court physician, and Uther's confidant and friend; as such, Gaius was given preferential treatment on the condition that he completely and immediately cease the practice of magic. He was allowed to keep some books on magic as "research" in case a magical threat arises; when Gaius becomes Merlin's mentor and caretaker, he is able to help him learn magic because he secretly kept some spellbooks. Inevitably, Gaius is viewed by many as a traitor in the magical community for catering to Uther even after the horrors of the purge. In "Punks, Bulldaggers, and Welfare Queens," Cathy J. Cohen discusses the need for intersectionality within the queer community, especially with regards to a proximity to power. Without this intersectionality, activists cannot relate to those with identities "which provide them with membership in and the resources of dominant institutions and groups" (78). Gaius occupies a precarious intersectionality in that he is neither a full member of the ruling class nor the magical community. Through his relationship to Uther, Gaius was able to survive the purge; however, he had to give up key aspects of his identity in order to retain his proximity to power. His closeness to Uther, however, is also quite dangerous: any misstep or suspicion of

magic could lead to execution. By conforming to societal standards, Gaius has conditional power through which he can aid those with magic while risking his life and status.

Although Morgana develops magic later in life, she is still classified as “witch” rather than a “sorceress.” Within the confines of *Merlin*, a warlock or witch is someone who is born with magical abilities, while a sorcerer or sorceress is someone with an affinity for magic who learns how to harness it. The Pendragons, of course, label all magic users as sorcerer or sorceress, spreading the propaganda that every magic user intentionally breaks the law to “become evil.” In “Queer and Now,” Eve Kosofsky Sedgwick points out that queer theory and general information on sexualities is essential to our society in allowing the youth to be better informed of their potential orientations, be more accepting of their identities, and decrease the risk of adolescent suicide within the queer community. Her thought that “this society wants its children to know nothing” (Sedgwick 4) and intentionally misinforms people about sexuality in an attempt to implicitly push them into heteronormativity is strikingly similar to how Uther spreads fallacies to encourage hatred and fear of magic. Growing up without training or guidance, young magic users learn to perceive themselves as monsters (“The Dragon’s Call”). As Sedgwick puts it, those who know nothing about sexuality and, by association, their own identities, must either “conform or die” (4), falling into society’s goal of removing queerness entirely. Morgana’s fears of her magic and others’ responses to her magic caused the goodness in her from the first season to, indeed, “die.” Her attempted coups of Camelot enable her to take revenge on those who caused her to fear for her life. During Morgana’s first coup, she tells Uther: “First I want you to suffer as I suffered. To know what it’s like to be alone and afraid. To be disgusted with who and what you are... You cannot begin to know how much I hate you” (“The Coming of Arthur: Part Two”). Morgana is unable to live tranquilly in a society that despises her existence; because she is unable to relinquish her

magical identity and conform to social standards, Morgana, Uther's ward, must die and be reborn as Morgana, the witch, for her own survival.

If nothing else, Merlin is clearly meant to represent those who feel that they must hide key parts of their identities in order to pass and survive. Judith Butler's *Gender Trouble* demonstrates that identity, in its many forms, is not only viewed as performative but also a social expectation. Regardless of a person's identity, society implicitly encourages people to perform in such a way that their appearance matches their expected identity. Performing one's expected identity is a survival strategy; after all, "Discrete genders are part of what 'humanizes' individuals within contemporary culture; indeed, we regularly punish those who fail to do their gender right" (2387). Though not necessarily with regards to gender, Merlin certainly performs as a non-magic user throughout the show for his own survival. The entire premise of the show is based on Merlin trying to hide his magic from others while blatantly using it to solve problems. Merlin lives in constant fear that his magic will be discovered, and he will be punished according to the law. As King Arthur, his best friend, is the law in Camelot, Merlin can never truly be himself around Arthur or any of his friends. It's only in the very last episode when Arthur is wounded and dying that Merlin finally reveals his magic in order to heal him. While Arthur initially rejects Merlin as an evil magic user, he eventually realizes that Merlin is still the same, good person, regardless of his magical abilities, and, in his final living moments, tells Merlin "I don't want you to change. I want you to always be you. I'm sorry about how I treated you" ("The Diamond of the Day: Part Two"). While the tragedy of Merlin finally getting acceptance from Arthur moments before his demise is evident, the message is clear. King Arthur, the epitome of morality and chivalry, declared that Merlin, the embodiment of magic and the Other, should embrace himself and not live in fear of his own identity. While no one else in Camelot was privy to this declaration,

the audience hears it all: the overarching purpose of BBC's *Merlin*, then, is to encourage viewers to accept themselves and others and inspire empathy for Othered individuals in real life.

In following Merlin's perspective for five seasons and sixty-five episodes, the audience grows intimate with Merlin's secretive position of constant anxiety and thus becomes frustrated with other characters, usually Arthur Pendragon, who are unable to understand Merlin's plights. No one knows what other people are experiencing at any given time: a little kindness and empathy goes a long way in making a difference in someone's life. Othered individuals, especially, require empathy, specifically from those in authority, in order to foster cultural inclusivity, acceptance, and respect. While *Merlin* doesn't explicitly bring up English colonial history, its allusions to the postcolonial Other and the undeniable history surrounding Arthurian legend encourages an interpretation of magic as indicative of the Other, specifically those Othered in modern-day Britain. BBC's *Merlin* is one of few adaptations of Arthurian legend to represent any notion of the Other, and it is the only Arthurian adaptation to represent various aspects of Othering. *Merlin's* success with viewers and depicting the Other may promote not only empathy and inclusivity but also future adaptations that serve to represent the Other.

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When The Stone Falls, Again: Repetition and Awareness in Time-Loop Narratives

Heather-Anne Jaeger

Time-loop narratives are structured through repetition and are a narrative form older than modern film or fiction. One of the earliest examples appears in Greek mythology through the tale of Sisyphus, a man condemned by the gods to push a stone up a mountain for eternity, only to watch it fall each time he reaches the summit. Although the task is endless and seemingly futile, Albert Camus famously concludes “The Myth of Sisyphus” with the doomed man at the foot of the mountain ready to embark on his next rotation up, and asserts that “one must imagine Sisyphus happy” (Camus 98). This conclusion reframes the myth not as a story of punishment by fate, but as one of awareness. For Camus, the critical moment occurs when Sisyphus becomes conscious of the absurdity of his condition, and through that awareness, his fate becomes his own.

This paper focuses on that moment, when the stone falls again, to examine how Camus’ philosophy of the absurd continues to resonate in contemporary storytelling. Rather than treating the myth of Sisyphus as an isolated philosophical thought experiment, this study considers how the experience Camus describes, the confrontation between the human desire for meaning and the repetitive structures of everyday life, reappears in modern time-loop narratives across film and literature. In contemporary contexts, this confrontation is not merely theoretical. Many individuals navigate monotonous routines while pursuing long-term goals, often without clear resolution or stability. These conditions are intensified by broader social and economic pressures, including unstable job markets, increasing demands for productivity, and the rapid expansion of technological systems that reshape labor and mindsets. At the same time, global instability, marked by ongoing conflict and declining trust in institutional leadership, further complicates individuals’ sense of purpose and direction. Within such conditions, existential concerns become

increasingly immediate rather than abstract. Time-loop narratives offer a framework for exploring these concerns. Films such as *Groundhog Day* and *Palm Springs*, alongside novels like *The Everlasting* and *Maybe Next Time*, can be used as examples to transform Camus' philosophical theory of the absurd into narrative and visual form. Through repetition, these texts ask not how to escape cyclical experience, but how to live within it, how meaning might be constructed when life begins to resemble repetition without resolution.

Camus and the Philosophy of the Absurd

Camus confronts this existential question directly in *The Myth of Sisyphus and Other Essays*. For Camus, the absurd emerges from a fundamental tension: humanity's deep desire for meaning colliding with a world that offers no clear answers. As he writes, "The absurd is born of this confrontation between the human need and the unreasonable silence of the world" (Camus 28). This condition reflects more than just human despair, but recognition, the realization that the search for ultimate meaning may remain unresolved. As Camus further explains, "The method defined here acknowledges the feeling that all true knowledge is impossible" (Camus 16). While individuals may seek certainty, such knowledge ultimately remains beyond reach.

To illustrate how this realization emerges, Camus turns to what he calls mechanical life. Much of human existence unfolds through routine: waking, working, returning home, and repeating the cycle. These patterns structure daily life so thoroughly that they often go unquestioned. The absurd begins, however, when this routine is interrupted by consciousness. At that moment, an individual confronts a simple yet unsettling question: why? Why this work, this life, this repetition? For Camus, this moment of questioning marks the awakening of consciousness, or awareness. As he writes, "For everything begins with consciousness and nothing is worth

anything except through it" (Camus 17). Once this awareness emerges, the individual cannot fully return to an unexamined routine. Instead, they must move forward within uncertainty, recognizing and accepting that definitive answers may never arrive.

This awakening also alters one's experience of time. With awareness comes recognition of its passage and, consequently, of mortality. Camus argues that fear of time is inseparable from fear of death, which remains unknowable because it lies beyond lived experience. "If time frightens us," he writes, "this is because it works out the problem and the solution comes afterward" (Camus 18). The tension between existence and meaning therefore remains unresolved. Camus articulates this limit clearly: "Between the certainty I have of my existence and the content I try to give to that assurance, the gap will never be filled" (Camus 21). Rather than resolving this gap, Camus shifts the question: if the world refuses to provide ultimate meaning, how should one live within that condition?

Sisyphus and the Absurd Hero

This is where Sisyphus enters Camus' philosophy. In the myth, he is condemned by the gods to push a stone up a mountain for eternity, only to watch it roll back down each time he reaches the summit. The task is endless, repetitive, and seemingly without purpose. For Camus, however, this very condition renders Sisyphus the ideal figure for understanding the absurd.

Sisyphus' punishment results from his own actions—his scorn of the gods, his resistance to death, and his enduring attachment to life. These choices condemn him to a task in which, as Camus writes, "the whole being is exerted toward accomplishing nothing" (Camus 96). Yet Camus challenges this conclusion by re-framing the meaning of the labor itself. Rather than asking whether the task has objective value, he considers how Sisyphus experiences it.

In this sense, Sisyphus' condition parallels the repetitive routines of modern life, in which individuals often move through daily structures without questioning their purpose. Camus therefore locates the significance of the myth not in the ascent, but in the moment when the stone falls and Sisyphus descends the mountain to begin again. It is in this interval that consciousness emerges. As Sisyphus turns back toward the stone, he becomes aware of his condition and recognizes that "his fate belongs to him" (Camus 97). The absurd, in this moment, is no longer something to escape but something to confront.

From this recognition follows Camus' well-known conclusion: one must imagine Sisyphus happy. The claim does not suggest that the task itself becomes meaningful, but that meaning arises through conscious engagement with it. Sisyphus' awareness transforms his condition from imposed punishment into a lived experience he can claim as his own.

Sisyphus thus comes to represent the human condition: a life structured by repetition, uncertainty, and the continual return to questions of meaning and purpose. His significance lies not in overcoming this condition, but in confronting it consciously. Within such repetition, individuals remain faced with a choice: to move through routine without reflection, or to engage with it deliberately and with awareness.

Time Loops as Narrative Absurdity

In many ways, modern time-loop narratives revisit this same philosophical situation. In these stories, characters are confined to repeating cycles: the same day, events, and choices unfolding with minimal variation. Like Sisyphus, they confront the disorienting experience of recurrence alongside the realization that their actions may lead to the same outcome.

Scholars have identified this structure as a distinct narrative form. As Wibke Schniedermann et al. explain, time-loop narratives

operate through a process of temporal reset in which “knowledge of the result of a process is sent back to the beginning of the same process and then becomes its input data” (4). With each iteration, the system evolves as characters retain memory from previous cycles, allowing awareness to accumulate even as the external conditions remain unchanged.

The significance of these narratives lies not in repetition alone, but in what repetition makes visible. Each cycle creates the possibility of recognition. Characters must determine whether to remain within unexamined routine or to confront the conditions of their experience consciously. In this way, time-loop narratives translate Camus’ philosophical model of the absurd into narrative form, rendering the tension between repetition and awareness through story.

Groundhog Day

One of the most recognizable modern examples of this narrative structure appears in the film *Groundhog Day*. Like Sisyphus, the protagonist Phil Connors is confined to a cycle of repetition, reliving February 2nd without variation. Each morning resets the sequence of events, regardless of his previous actions. In this sense, the film reflects the feedback loop described by Schniedermann, in which knowledge gained in one iteration carries forward into the next. Phil retains memory across cycles, allowing his awareness to develop even as the external conditions remain unchanged. The day persists in repetition, but Phil does not.

As the film’s writer, Danny Rubin, explains, the premise was never intended as a purely comedic device. Instead, it emerged from a broader philosophical question concerning the experience of endless life. By reimagining eternity not as an extended timeline but as the repetition of a single day, Rubin reframes the narrative as an inquiry into how one lives under conditions of recurrence. The film thus shifts from a question of structure to one of response.

Phil's initial reaction to the loop reflects a nihilistic response to the absence of consequence. If each day resets, actions appear to lose significance. He indulges impulses, disregards social norms, and ultimately tests the limits of the cycle through self-destructive behavior. However, as repetition continues, Phil's condition begins to resemble the absurd as articulated by Camus. Unable to escape the cycle and offered no explanation for its existence, he confronts the limits of control within a repetitive structure.

The transformation occurs not through escape, but through a shift in awareness. Phil gradually abandons attempts to manipulate the outcome of the day and instead begins to engage with it consciously. He develops skills, attends to others, and reorients his actions toward intentional living. Therefore, by echoing Camus' conclusion that "one must imagine Sisyphus happy," Phil's narrative illustrates that the significance of repetition lies not in changing the cycle itself, but in transforming one's relationship to it.

In this way, *Groundhog Day* translates Camus' philosophical model into narrative form. Phil's eventual release from the loop does not signify the resolution of the absurd, but rather the culmination of his transformation within it. Like Sisyphus, his movement forward emerges not from overcoming repetition, but from confronting it with awareness.

Palm Springs

A more recent example of the time-loop narrative appears in the film *Palm Springs*, often regarded as a contemporary successor to *Groundhog Day*. Film analyst Christopher Bingham characterizes the film as an evolutionary extension of Danny Rubin's original concept, noting that, while not explicitly derived from *Groundhog Day*, its structure closely resembles elements present in early drafts of Rubin's script (00:08:30). These earlier versions included younger protagonists, characters already aware

of the loop, and a narrative that more fully explored the hedonistic and destabilizing effects of endless repetition (00:05:00). As Bingham suggests, if these discarded elements were recombined, the resulting narrative would closely resemble *Palm Springs*.

What distinguishes *Palm Springs*, however, is its shift from an individual to a shared experience of repetition. When Sarah becomes trapped in the loop alongside Nyles, the narrative expands from a singular trajectory of transformation to a comparative framework of response. Rather than tracing one character's development, the film presents multiple orientations toward the same condition. Nyles embodies resignation. Having spent years within the cycle, he no longer seeks meaning or escape, instead adapting to repetition through detachment and indulgence. Roy, by contrast, represents anger, responding to the loop through fixation and revenge. Sarah introduces a third position: confrontation. Rather than accepting the cycle or reacting against it, she attempts to understand its structure, studying the mechanics of the loop in order to disrupt it.

Through this configuration, *Palm Springs* extends the philosophical implications of repetition beyond individual transformation. While *Groundhog Day* demonstrates how awareness can emerge gradually within a single subject, *Palm Springs* reveals that the absurd condition does not produce a uniform response. Instead, repetition generates multiple possibilities – resignation, anger, or conscious confrontation – each reflecting a different mode of engaging with the limits of control.

Transition into Literary Narratives

While films such as *Groundhog Day* and *Palm Springs* render repetition visually immediate, contemporary literature engages time-loop narratives in ways that emphasize interiority and reflection. In these texts, repetition functions not only as a structural device but as a means of returning characters to pivotal

moments in their lives. Through this return, characters confront the limits of control and reassess their relationship to time, experience, and choice.

The Everlasting

In Alix E. Harrow's *The Everlasting*, the time loop is anchored to a single location: the Yew Tree. Each time Professor Owen Mallory travels through time, he returns to this site, which functions as both the origin point of the narrative and the locus of its repetition. The tree is also shared across Owen and Una's respective pasts, positioning it as the connective space through which their timelines converge and the cycle is sustained.

Each attempt Owen makes to alter Una's fate requires returning to this moment. Yet every intervention ultimately produces the same outcome, gradually revealing the limits of his ability to control events. As the cycle repeats, Owen comes to recognize that the historical narrative he was sent to recover is itself constructed. What he initially accepts as historical truth is exposed as "a story designed to teach us who to hate and who to obey" (Harrow 183). This recognition leads Owen toward a moment of consciousness that parallels Camus' absurd hero. As he realizes that his efforts to control the future only perpetuate the cycle, he makes the one choice he has not yet attempted: he sacrifices himself. In relinquishing control, he disrupts the loop anchored to the Yew Tree and releases both himself and Una from the narrative imposed upon them.

Owen's transformation reflects the logic of the absurd. The cycle begins to shift not through mastery or intervention, but through the acceptance of its limits. While *The Everlasting* uses time travel to explore the repetition of historical narratives, it also points toward a broader concern shared by time-loop stories: how repetition compels individuals to reconsider the conditions of their lives.

Maybe Next Time

This inward perspective appears in Cesca Major's *Maybe Next Time*, a novel inspired by the author's experience during the 2020 pandemic. It follows Emma, a woman whose intense focus on her career has gradually distanced her from those around her. She becomes trapped reliving the day her husband Dan dies, forced to confront the same tragedy repeatedly. No matter what she alters, the day always culminates at 10:17 p.m., the moment of Dan's death. Each morning resets to the beginning of the same sequence, and Emma initially responds by attempting to control every detail, hoping to prevent the inevitable. Yet each effort produced the same result.

Over time, this repetition reshapes Emma's understanding of her life. In one of the novel's most revealing moments, she tells Dan what the experience has taught her: "I used to think I could stop it... but eventually it made me realize how much time I've wasted on the wrong things... when all I wanted was more time with you" (Major 364). Like the other characters discussed in this study, Emma first approaches the cycle through control. Only when she recognizes its limits does the significance of the experience become clear. The repetition does not exist to alter Dan's fate, but to force Emma into a moment of awareness about how she has been living, prompting her to reconnect with her children, support those around her, and reconsider the imbalance between her work and personal life. In this sense, the true beginning of Emma's story lies not in the repeated day, but in the fifteen years she had already been given with her husband. Through this realization, the novel reflects Camus' insight that awareness of life's limits can reshape how individuals choose to live within them.

Conclusion

Across these but few narrative examples, from Sisyphus to contemporary time-loop texts, a consistent pattern emerges: repetition compels characters to confront the conditions of their own lives. Movement forward becomes possible only through consciousness, through the recognition of the absurdity that structures their experience. As Camus argues, the absurd does not eliminate meaning; instead, it reveals that meaning must be created. Sisyphus persists in his labor because he chooses to confront it.

Time-loop narratives extend Camus's philosophical insight by demonstrating how repetition produces moments of awareness. These texts suggest that while individuals cannot control the broader conditions shaping their lives, whether social, political, or economic, they retain the capacity to determine how they engage with those conditions. In this sense, repetition does not merely signal stagnation; it becomes a site of potential transformation.

Camus' formulation ultimately reframes the question of escape. The task is not to transcend the cycle, but to inhabit it consciously. The stone will continue to fall; routines will persist, and definitive answers may remain inaccessible. Yet within this ongoing return lies the possibility of deliberate engagement. It is in this moment, when the individual turns again toward the task, that Camus' conclusion resonates most clearly: one must imagine Sisyphus happy.

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Scopophilia and Revenance: Empowering Shakespeare's Lavinia in Julie Taymor's *Titus*

Jessica Charest

Throughout much of the critical analysis of Shakespeare's bloody revenge tragedy, *Titus Andronicus*, Lavinia's role as one of only two female characters in the play is often examined for either her silence or the physical harm done to her, often dismissing her potential as a revenger. Little changes when turning from literary analysis of the play itself to film analysis of recent screen adaptations. Lavinia is often dismissed as a silent, passive figure whose suffering is just one violent and vengeful act in a play filled with violence and vengeance. However, Lavinia's silence and visually ravaged body present her with an avenue of power most typically associated with ghosts in revenge tragedies. Stephen Greenblatt discusses the obligation of revengers to remember the revenant beings who haunt them, particularly noting examples such as Hamlet and Brutus who experience this remembrance as "a link manifested in terror, commandment, and *the inescapable obligation to remember*" (218, emphasis added). The living do not choose to remember or forget the dead; rather, the dead haunt the living and force them to remember through proximity and vision. Likewise, Lavinia's physical form haunts the background of the play, forcing those around her to continually remember the wrongs done to her, and consequently, to the Adronici name. Julie Taymor's 1999 adaptation, *Titus*, enhances viewers' understanding of the play by enabling the visual impact of Lavinia's body to be rendered more effective through techniques that draw the audience's gaze, both viewers and the other characters of the play alike, to Lavinia's form and work to shape our interpretation. Lavinia's silent, mutilated form, emerging as a revenant figure, visually manipulates those around her, enabling her to act not as a passive figure in Shakespeare's work, but rather as an agent working toward her own revenge within the social confines of the world that marginalized her.

In labeling Lavinia a “female revenant” one must first consider what it means to be a revenant by definition. The most common conception of a revenant typically resonates most with the vengeful ghost motif of many classical and early modern revenge tragedies -- those who haunt the stage (or screen) to witness and inspire vengeance. However, a revenant need not be a noncorporeal or nonliving entity. The *Oxford English Dictionary* (OED) defines the adjectival form of the word as having “returned from, or as if from, the dead; resembling or reminiscent of, a ghost” (“revenant,” emphasis added). It is important to note that at no point does the OED’s definition of revenant ever specify that the being in question must be dead; rather, the revenant creature merely needs to bear some resemblance to a ghost or returned spirit of the dead. The French origin of revenant, “revenir” lends further significance to the misconception that a revenant being must be one who died and returned from beyond the grave, as it is a verb merely meaning to return after an absence. Arguably, the OED’s exclusion of actual death in its own definition of a revenant, combined with the term’s French origins, present space for an expanded conceptualization of spectrality and revenance to shed light on gendered implications behind revenants in early modern drama. Unlike their male counterparts, who almost always emerge as actual ghosts, devoid of a physical form and unable to directly interact with the world around them, female revenants are often living beings, relegated to a haunting-like role but who possess a physical form and can both influence and participate in their desired acts of revenge. Lavinia, raped and deprived of both tongue and hands, epitomizes this living-ghostly role.

Although Lavinia spoke few lines even prior to her disfiguration, her silent figure speaks loudly to her male relatives and to the audience who sees her transformation. Taymor follows the original text in revealing the horror and discomfort Lavinia’s family, particularly her brother and uncle, experience upon the sight of her bloody and ravished form. Upon bringing Lavinia’s

altered form, her uncle, Marcus claims that “This was thy daughter” (Titus 1:14:11-1:14:13; Shakespeare 3.1.62). Similarly, her own brother, Lucius, upon seeing her body, exclaims “Ay me, *this object* kills me” and “Speak, gentle sister: who hath *martyred* thee?” (Titus 1:14:23-1:14:24; 1:15:14-1:15:17; Shakespeare 3.1.64; 3.1.81, emphasis added). It is little surprise that her male relatives cease to view Lavinia as a woman and a human being following her rape. As Catharine R. Stimson observes in her criticism of the play, “For women, rape means both submission, death, and more” (Stimson 59). Transformed by rape and mutilation, Lavinia’s body shifts within the play, disrupting the image of her as untainted virgin, a symbol of Rome itself, replacing it instead with an image of violation and horror. Even Titus himself refers to Lavinia as something other than human. While he denies Marcus’s claim that Lavinia is no longer herself, he speaks of her as though she has changed. Matthew Blasi notes how Titus shifts to viewing Lavinia less like his own child and begins to “objectify her as an ‘it’” after she returns from her rape (Blasi 9). In fact, despite the other trials Titus faces throughout the text, it is Lavinia’s ever-present body that continually haunts him, as he refers to her as items such as a “map of woe” (Titus 1:30:14; Shakespeare 3.2.12). Her constant silent presence throughout the rest of the play continually acts to remind Titus and the audience of her suffering and the need to avenge her.

While Shakespeare’s play itself leaves significant verbal cues to demonstrate the horror with which Lavinia’s relations receive her mutilated body, Taymor’s *Titus* uses visual and film techniques to enhance the visual effect in a way that invites the audience to experience the same discomfort as Titus and the other male characters. Much of Taymor’s film takes a unique approach to adapting the play by having the audience identify with the character of Young Lucius, a boy whose role has been expanded from a minor character to a silent spectator, witnessing many scenes directly. Mary Lindroth comments on the scenes where we are not aligned directly with Young Lucius’s viewpoint, identifying the fact that

although the camera itself takes over as spectator, it tends to leave violent acts just off-screen and instead focuses on the reactions to that violence (Lindroth 111). In creating a link between male character gazes, the camera, and the audience, Taymor actively utilizes a concept of apparatus theory promulgated by Laura Mulvey— the concept of the *male gaze*. According to Mulvey, “In their traditional exhibitionist role women are simultaneously looked at and displayed, with their appearance coded for strong visual and erotic impact so that they can be said to connote *to-be-looked-at-ness*” (Mulvey 436). In Taymor’s film, Lavinia takes on the role of spectacle, subject to the male gaze. However, as Mulvey notes, the lack of male genitals also makes gazing at the female figure a source of castration anxiety for male viewers, something that must be dealt with in some way to take away the displeasure caused by that anxiety (Mulvey 438). Lavinia’s representation goes a step further by acting not only as a reminder of her lack of maleness but as a visual representation of the violation of herself (and consequently of Rome).

Lavinia’s transition into spectacle occurs in a scene impossible to forget or look away from—her post-raped and mutilated form standing on a stump as if on a pedestal, while her uncle, discovering her, slowly walks toward her in horror. While Taymor condenses Marcus’s lengthy speech on Lavinia’s body, the discovery scene is still long and drawn out as we watch ribbons of crimson blood drift from Lavinia’s mouth and stare at the branches protruding from where her hands should be. Philippa Sheppard comments on the disturbing quality of the scene, stating, “The visual contrasts of [Lavinia’s] pale skin and white dress against the backdrop of the stark, black, burnt remnants of trees, the black twigs attached to her arms, her black hair blowing in the wind, and the red blood were gorgeous. But should they be?” (Sheppard 220). Indeed, the beauty of the scene is essential to Lavinia’s centrality to the film. The very nature of the scene is both artfully designed and openly disturbing to the viewers, both Marcus and the film’s audience. Taymor takes the two forms of scopophilia that Mulvey

posits—fetishistic (the shifting of the represented figure into a fetish to make it reassuring rather than dangerous) and voyeuristic (the investigating and punishing of the guilty object) and seems to complicate these two ideas (Mulvey 438). Lavinia's body is ravished and mutilated in a way that mirrors the voyeuristic approach, yet she remains a horrifyingly beautiful image that arrests the gaze.

Although reduced by her mutilation to a spectacle, Lavinia does manage to actively participate in a pivotal scene to the plot. However, when Lavinia finally manages to convey the identities of her rapists, the audience witnesses a strangely artistic scene that takes us into a metaphoric re-experiencing of the rape. Several critics have noticed Taymor's seeming allusion to the fetishistic scopophilia of the famous Marilyn Monroe scene from *The Seven Year Itch* (1955) in the form of Lavinia's imagined recollection of the moment. As Lindroth describes, "Lavinia appears on a tree stump in the middle of a barren swamp, clothed in a white dress with flared skirt that is blowing up, reminiscent of the famous Marilyn Monroe shot over the subway grate" (Lindroth 112). Rather than just allowing us to witness a rare moment of Lavinia breaking out of her specter role and acting, Taymor once more presents viewers with a scopophilic image of her, one in which the accompanying horrified gaze of Marcus Andronicus mirrors that of the audience themselves. The scene takes this parallel to a classic fetishistic image and adds animalistic elements to continue a metaphor from Shakespeare's original text—Lavinia likened to a doe subjected to the merciless claws of the tigers (Chiron and Demetrius). In stylizing the rape this way, Taymor seems to take a scene that would typically be interpreted by Mulvey as voyeuristic scopophilia—a punishing gaze that removes castration anxiety— and instead translates it into a fetishistic moment. In complicating the way we are meant to view this scene, Taymor instead seems to make viewers stop to truly *see* Lavinia while refusing to strip away that fear of castration anxiety. Instead, Lavinia becomes more than just a female body— she becomes a monstrous female body, a threat.

Prior to her sudden burst of action, Lavinia exists only as something that needs to be appeased, much like her fallen brethren in their ancestral tomb early in the play. Upon seeing her ravished form, Titus asks her to “Make some signs how I may do thee ease” (*Titus* 1:16:30-1:16:31; Shakespeare 3.1.121). Feminine womb and the more masculine-coded tomb are intricately linked in a cycle similar to the cyclical revenge Lavinia and Tamora enforce throughout the play. The tomb, however, openly becomes a supernatural site early in the play. Lucius proposes to “sacrifice” Alarbus to the tomb, stating:

Give us the proudest prisoner of the Goths,
That we may hew his limbs, and on a pile
Ad manes fratrum sacrifice his flesh
Before this earthly prison of their bones,
That so the shadows be not unappeased,
Nor we disturbed with prodigies on earth.

(*Titus* 10:28-10:39; Shakespeare 1.1.96-101)

“Prodigies” here refers to the possibility of unnatural — or supernatural — events. The idea of appeasement once more conjures the idea of revenants: although the spirits of Titus’s dead sons never appear on stage, their presence in the tomb demands sacrifice and appeasement. Yet, unlike the ancestral tomb, Lavinia is a constant presence that requests appeasement through the visual reminder of her deformity. She is not only the object of others’ gazes; she stands in the background and silently gazes back. The weight of her gaze and the ever-present unnatural image her body presents constantly threatens the male Andronici, reminding them of the danger to their family name and integrity. If, in this sense, she becomes a revenant figure requiring appeasement just as the souls of her dead brothers early in the plot, the living Andronici have no choice but to avenge her to free themselves from the spectacle. Lavinia emerges like the dead men Aaron later proclaims to have dug up and set at their loved one’s door, with “Let not your sorrow die, though I am dead” carved into their flesh (*Titus* 2:09:35-2:09:56; Shakespeare 5.1.136-141). Though still alive,

she returns to her family, visibly mutilated, a constant reminder to Titus of his vulnerability and loss.

Taymor closely follows Shakespeare in scripting the scene of Chiron and Demetrius's death as though it were a sacrificial offering to Lavinia's desecrated body. Titus invites Lavinia into the room with him where Chiron and Demetrius are strung up on meat hooks, naked and gagged, primed for slaughter. Importantly, Lavinia holds a basin between her two stumps, which she uses when Titus slits the throats of the two rapists and exclaims, "... Lavinia, come, / Receive the blood" (*Titus* 2:22:57-2:23:08; Shakespeare 5.2.196-197). Lavinia not only gets to witness the murder of her tormenters, but she gets to actively take part, accepting their blood into the basin as though she were a vengeful spirit finally receiving its due. Linda Williams makes the claim that "Even in the most extreme displays of feminine masochistic suffering, there is always a component of either power or pleasure for the woman victim (Williams 8). In the case of Lavinia, her suffering form seems to grant her a power over the male gaze that she originally lacked when she still had a voice and an unblemished body.

Despite the necessity of Lavinia's horrifying form being the object of fetishistic scopophilia, however, once she has prompted the male characters to act, to purge that which has threatened her and their own security, the anxiety must be eliminated as well. The sacrifice Lavinia receives concludes her revenge and transforms her back into the form of a ravished woman. As a revenant, Lavinia controls the narrative of her revenge, while Titus merely serves as the tool for that revenge. Compelled to return like an automaton, the revenant moves in a behavioral loop if it remains unappeased, trapped in a state of unrest. Once her rapists have been sacrificed, the film returns to Mulvey's concept of voyeuristic scopophilia, in which Lavinia is punished— in this case through death at her own father's hands. As Saturninus assures Titus, a raped daughter should die "Because the girl should not survive her shame, / And by her presence still renew his sorrows" (*Titus*

2:27:37-2:27:41; Shakespeare 5.3.41-42). By existing, Lavinia serves as a reminder of her lost virginity and the loss to the Andronici family honor.

Interestingly, however, Taymor chooses to differ from Shakespeare in one key aspect — the mode of Lavinia's death. Although Shakespeare's Lavinia dies through stabbing, in Taymor's version, Lavinia's body is the only one to die in the final scenes without being penetrated by a weapon. Titus stabs Tamora with a butcher knife. Saturninus avenges his empress by thrusting a sharp chandelier through Titus's chest. Lucius avenges his father by murdering Saturninus with a spoon down the throat and a gunshot. While these bodies become bloody corpses, the final view of Lavinia looks serene, as if she could merely be sleeping, unstained by the carnage around her. Even as she must be punished to resolve the anxieties of the male characters in the film, Lavinia remains that beautiful spectacle, more feminine than any previous shot of her, all deformities and blemishes absent from view.

In arresting the gaze, both of her male family members and of the viewers, Lavinia does not halt the action of the film but rather serves as a constant reminder of the violation both to her own body and that of Rome. Her hybridity blends her identity with Rome itself — and even with the modern day world due to Rome's hybrid temporality in the film. Through this, audience members are never allowed to forget these violent excesses, and just like Titus, they wish to see a purgation of the very sights that not only enrapture us but also make us uncomfortably aware of our enrapturement. When her male relatives, and alongside them, us as the audience, begin to stagnate, Lavinia's presence is there to shock and horrify, to, as Mulvey says, "connote *to-be-looked-at-ness*" and to stimulate the need for action. In the hands of Julie Taymor, fetishistic scopophilia mixes with the punishing nature of voyeuristic scopophilia, allowing a passive figure like Lavinia to be the driving force behind the action rather than an object outside of the narrative.

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Maternity and Witches: A New Way of Witchery in *Weapons*

Reagan Oliveira

Bathed in the red glow of a shiftily dive-bar, local school-teacher Justine Grandy (Julia Garner) wryly admits to small-town cop Paul Morgan (Alden Ehrenreich), “Everybody thinks I’m a witch” (00:17:12). Though the comment is fleeting, the insult of being called a witch possesses an ugly connotation that harkens back to late medieval and Early Modern misogynistic beliefs about women and their inherent capacity for evil. Since the early 17th century, the cultural mythos of the “witch” has plagued America’s collective psyche. Constructed from religious documents from the 15th century, such as the *Malleus Maleficarum*, the figure of the witch is described as antithetical to the entirety of Christendom. In addition to the witch’s compulsion to deconstruct the heteronormative family unit--which was jeopardized by her untrammelled sexual desire and taste for children’s flesh--she also possessed a voracious appetite for power, which was marginally allocated in exchange for a covenant with the devil. The witch’s proximity to and subversion of traditionally feminized gender roles rendered the figure a “gendered entity,” further establishing her supernatural abilities as an inherent threat to patriarchal order (Carroll 2019). Though the historical brutality that women accused of witchcraft endured popularized the figure for First and Second Wave Feminists, who self-identified with the witch’s desire to exist outside of patriarchal control, the figure has since been complicated by the Third and Fourth Wave belief of choice feminism. As women are increasingly returning to the domestic sphere and re-aligning themselves with traditional gender roles, Zach Cregger’s 2025 film, *Weapons*, offers an interpretation of witchhood that is depicted as an option and not just as an alternative to patriarchal control, contrasting the varied application of the title of “witch” to Justine and Aunt Gladys (Amy Madigan), clarifying how each woman is societally viewed in response to the term.

Historically, feminists have identified with the witch because feminist witchcraft was perceived as less violent than Christianity and more sexually and socially liberating. According to Lauren Zwissler, feminists identified less with the practice of witchcraft and more with what the witch represented: “Witch’ stands for a woman not properly subservient to patriarchy: a political rebel. If a witch is a woman who is not doing what men want her to do, then she is the original feminist, and today’s feminists are just the newest witches” (15). This iteration of the witch is perhaps more in line with the beliefs of Second Wave feminists, who rejected patriarchal control and codified gender norms. As such, horror films such as *Rosemary’s Baby* (1968) depict typically feminine roles, like wife and mother, as monstrous and simply horrifying. These films utilized the witch as a social thermometer to reflect contemporary opinions about the role of motherhood in feminism, as “Horror films, sharing a cultural continuum with early modern witch fears, arguably their own precursors, are always also about gender and sexuality, no matter what else they are doing” (Zwissler 5). However, through the contemporary rise of choice feminism, *Weapons* suggests a feminist reading of motherhood through Gladys’ downfall.

The film follows the events of a small town after 17 children from Justine Grandy’s class mysteriously disappear overnight at 2:17 in the morning. Though camera footage reveals that the children left their homes of their own accord, the townspeople are unconvinced that Justine is uninvolved due to her proximity to the children and her own sordid past. Told through a *Rashomon*-style narrative, the film combines contemporary fears about the “weaponization” of young and vulnerable people with medieval and folkloric beliefs about witches to indicate a shift in the collective unconscious about women and motherhood. Historically, the initial gendering of the witch derived from misinterpreted scriptures and other religious documents that cited women as “...the weaker sex and thus more vulnerable to the Devil’s possession” (Blackmore and Pugh 2). In *Weapons*, Justine is

immediately characterized as a witch because of her untraditional behavior and adulterous past. Archer (Josh Brolin), the father of one of the missing children, takes it upon himself to present her previous affair with a fellow teacher as an indication of her capacity for evil, bringing the record of her past sexuality to the police as proof that she must be further investigated.

Archer's displeasure with Justine's sexual nature is based on her close proximity to children despite the fact that she lives alone and lacks her own family, instead inserting herself into others' family units. Early modern beliefs contended that because female generativity and spiritual health were interdependent upon one another, stringent gender codes that exercised control over reproduction and the female body were necessary to uphold and maintain safe and morally-upright societies. If women neglected their child-rearing duties, they were "...at risk of genuinely believing they were witches as they were so thoroughly permeated by religious ideologies that they considered themselves vile and evil by nature" (Carroll 3). In one anonymous account of 17th century witchcraft, the author describes how Ioane Flower, "a monstrous malicious woman," exploited her unmarried and fertile daughter, Phillip, to seduce a young man within their community: "Concerning Phillip, that she was lewdly transported with the love of one Thomas Sympson, who presumed to say, that she had bewitched him; for he had no power to leave her, and was (as hee supposed) maruellously altered both in minde and bodie, since her acquainted company" (5). From this religious context, Justine's sexual appetite for married men implicates her as a threat not just to the nuclear family structure, but to patriarchal society in general, as her rampant promiscuity outside the bounds of marriage and children perpetuates Early Modern fears about displaced femininity, even within the 21st century.

Given patriarchal society's fear of unbridled female generativity, one might believe the majority of women accused of witchcraft would be young and of child-birthing age. However, Rikke Schubart posits that "...at least half and possibly more (of

women accused of witchcraft) were over forty,” demonstrating a clear prejudice or mistrust towards aging women (5). The hag or crone is despised and described in terms of abjection, in which her body “...disturbs identity, system, order” (Crowther 3). Though accusations of witchcraft began to wane in the late 18th century, the audacity of the hag witch and themes of ageism bled well into the 19th century, depicted in popular fairy-tales such as the Brothers Grimm’s “Hansel and Gretel” and “Snow White” (1812). In “Hansel and Gretel,” the evil hag witch attempts to deceive the children to entrap them in her home and consume them, perpetuating the medieval belief that witches engage in satanic rituals such as cannibalism and pedicide. Further, the wicked sorceress queen of “Snow White” is perhaps more indicative of the societally entrenched prejudice against aging women, as she upholds the narrative that elderly women are morally decrepit and envious. According to sociologists Jay Ginn and Sara Arber, “Because women’s value is sexualized, positively in the first half of life, (and) negatively in the second,” ageism and sexism are interconnected and construct societies that neglect and are resentful of women in their older age (Schubart 3). In this, not only are aging women pitted against their younger, feminine counterparts, but children are conditioned to be fearful and suspicious of older, “haggish” women for their capacity for evil.

For Carl Gustav Jung, the significance of fairy-tales extends beyond instilling a moral compass within the younger generation. Like the horror genre itself, which materializes our unconscious fears into monstrous figures, fairy-tales “...represent a spontaneous expression of archetypal motifs, characters, and symbols of the collective unconscious” (Kovačević 11). In *Weapons*, Gladys Lilly, the haggish crone, first makes her appearance in the dreams of several townspeople before she ever makes her official on-screen debut. Interestingly, Gladys first appears within Justine’s dreams, who the town already accuses of being a witch. The early interactions between Gladys and Justine within the liminal dream space are reminiscent of “Snow White,” in which the old crone

haunts and harasses a young woman out of jealousy for her vigor and beauty. Justine is youthful, pretty, and maternal; she is reprimanded by her principal, Marcus Miller (Benedict Wong), for consistently over-stepping professional bounds with her students in a well-meaning effort to care for them. He chastises, "I know that you aren't a threat to these kids, but you have to realize, you aren't a parent, you're a teacher," revealing Justine's misplaced maternal instinct (0:14:20). Cregger intentionally plays with the lessons that fairy-tales typically impart upon its viewers by casting Justine as an untrustworthy "witch" who entices her students and lures them away from their parents, while Gladys, the true harbinger of dark magic, manages to infiltrate the town seemingly unnoticed. Her introduction to the town through their dreams indicates that her presence is something so abhorrent that it resides in the residents' unconscious, just beyond where they allow themselves to look.

When Gladys moves in with Alex (Cary Christopher), her nephew and the sole child not targeted by her witchcraft, she invades his family unit like a parasite. The image of the parasite consistently reappears throughout the film once Gladys is introduced; Justine teaches a lesson on different types of parasites to her students the day Gladys arrives to town, and Marcus Miller watches a nature documentary on the *Ophiocordyceps unilateralis* fungus, or the "zombie ant fungus," shortly before she casts a spell on him to do her evil bidding. In reference to the film's title, Gladys utilizes her magic to weaponize people to carry out acts of murder and attain items necessary for future spells as a type of parasitic witch. Deborah Willis posits that "The destructive potential of the witch is closely tied to that of the murdering mother," in which patriarchal fears about the breakdown of the tenuous family unit inform the mythology surrounding witchcraft practices. As a result, though Gladys' intention to target a group of small children is initially unclear, her initial interactions with Alex are intrinsically dreadful because they are reminiscent of the culturally odious anti or bad mother. Later, the audience learns that Gladys is incredibly ill and presumably needs to feed on the

life-force of young people to stay alive. Her desire for unnatural youth calls upon the medieval and folkloric cannibalistic urges of witches, who would slaughter and consume children to create a covenant with the devil and achieve eternal life through “palpable and forcible touches of sucking, pinching, kissing, closing, colling, and such like” (3). Though she does not intend to physically consume the 17 children, as represented in “Hansel and Gretel,” she similarly hides them within her home and feeds off of their souls to reverse her terminal illness. However, Gladys seems to be aware of these haggish myths as she threatens Alex with the well-being of his parents: “I can make your parents hurt themselves. I can make them hurt each other. I can make them eat each other if I want to.” (1:37:28) Gladys calls upon these archetypal motifs to extract the horror from within Alex’s unconscious and control him as a host being without ever having to cast a spell, due to her diabolical nature and her own knowledge of the cultural mythology surrounding witches.

In addition to infiltrating his family unit, Gladys also slowly transforms his home, the place of comfort and safety, into an ungodly space of witchcraft and fear. Gladys primarily operates within the domestic sphere, utilizing household items to cast her spells and practice witchcraft as, “Cooking is a central motif in the representation of female witchcraft, and the site of cooking defines the space that is assigned to the witch” (Rogel 7). She initially threatens Alex and his family at the dinner table, a place for familial connection over food, forcing his parents to stab themselves in the face with kitchen utensils. Similarly, she utilizes common household items such as bowls, scissors, and twine to create talismans that control others. However, *Weapons* subverts the traditionally feminine behavior of nourishing and fostering a family when Gladys refuses to feed Alex, his parents, or any of the children held captive in the basement. She instructs him: “You’ll need to feed your parents. There’s soup in the cabinet. Tomorrow, you’ll get some more.” (1:39:15) Gladys’ anti-maternalism runs so deeply to the extent that she forces Alex to take on the caretaker role; the

audience watches as the young boy struggles to open a can of soup, spilling half its contents onto the floor, before clumsily spoon-feeding his catatonic parents, still frozen at the dining table. Her unwillingness to feed and sustain Alex simultaneously reinforces her own gross degenerativity, as her progressively aging and deteriorating appearance eliminates any possibility for sexual potential. Though Gladys never eats within the film herself, there is a recurring motif of food and consuming that appears throughout the film. Marcus is sitting down to an afternoon snack when Gladys interrupts him and promptly casts a spell in his kitchen that causes Marcus to kill his partner. In this, the act of eating and extreme violence are linked together, depicting the function as grotesque and overtly carnal. Gladys' disregard for the sanctity of the home and the domestic sphere is represented through motifs like food and eating, subverting the traditionally feminine roles of homemaker and mother for covenant with the devil and eternal life.

The home also becomes a space of great violence after Gladys attempts to murder Justine and Archer by ambushing them within the seemingly deserted home. After the door to Alex's home opens in a dream-like sequence by Gladys' invisible hand, Justine and Archer enter into the mysterious home as a pair, eerily reminiscent of *Hansel and Gretel*, in an attempt to find the missing children. Gladys immediately sends her zombified cronies to stop the two from discovering the children, including sickening Alex's parents upon him so that he cannot warn the pair. Interestingly, the kitchen becomes a pivotal center of gendered violence, as Justine must kill her previous love-interest with various instruments found throughout the kitchen. In one stomach-churning scene, Justine skins the flesh from Paul's cheek using a vegetable peeler, referencing Gladys' previous acts of violence against Alex's parents in a kind of gendered solidarity. However, Alex manages to break Gladys' spell by casting his own—he recreates the talisman that enspells and weaponizes the 17 children, setting them upon the witch herself in a Bacchic frenzy. While the scene begins comically, as Gladys fervently runs from the pack of children, her demise is

exceptionally gruesome. She is ripped apart, piece by piece, until she is nothing more than a bloodied mass of errant body parts the children ritualistically circle.

The grotesque nature of Gladys' death, which recalls the death of Orpheus at the hands of the Thracian women, as well as Alex's role in defeating the evil hag witch, suggests a shift in feminist views of motherhood. Built from the motifs and archetypes from medieval beliefs and fairy tales, Gladys operates much like a 19th century witch, subverting domestic spaces and the maternal instinct into something monstrous and horrifying. Despite the fact that Justine's character is inherently contrasted against Gladys, as she is young, pretty, and more maternal in nature, her sexual immorality also lends itself to the witch trope and causes the town to suspect her of foul-play. In this, *Weapons* does not seek to rewrite the mythology of the witch—in fact, the film foments it to unearth primordial, unconscious fears about gender and sexuality within a contemporary setting. Rather, the film imagines a feminist reading of motherhood in which Gladys, the abject, monstrous witch, is not shackled by the patriarchy, yet continues to subvert the domestic sphere. Her distance from patriarchal control suggests a new way of witchery that is not a response to traditional female gender roles—including motherhood—but is a conscious “choice,” indicative of her feminist rights.

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